her intention to forge a federal front of non-Congress, non-BJP parties. And Jayalalithaa, too, had said she was in the prime ministerial race. If there was a prospect more nightmarish than Kejriwal for the business world, it was the revival of a khichdi sarkar.

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Teen Deviyan is a 1965 Bollywood film where Dev Anand, the hero, courts three women—Nanda, Simi Garewal and Kalpana. In early 2014, Lutyens' Delhi would joke of how the next prime minister needed the support of at least two of three women leaders—Mamata, Jayalalithaa and Mayawati—to form a government. All three were expected to get between twenty and thirty seats, so any party or pre-poll alliance that crossed 200 seats but was short of the 272-seat majority would need their support. 'Just think of it, the prime minister will go crazy having to deal with them!' a senior bureaucrat laughed.

Mamata, Jayalalithaa and Mayawati—women who have endured a brutally patriarchal world of Indian politics and have survived to play and to win. Scarred by their battles, what seems to unite them is a stern authoritarianism in their leadership styles, and being the centre of a personality cult that commands the reverence of their male cadres. The ladies are doughty, intolerant fighters, yet trapped in a way by the family honorifics of Didi, Amma and Behenji.

Of the troika, I know Mamata best. For some reason, Didi appeared to have a soft corner for me. She would call me over for tea, give me lengthy interviews and had offered me a Rajya Sabha seat, which I politely declined. She even cooked a Bengali meal for me once. The sight of the Bengal chief minister in the kitchen, her crumpled sari tied in a no-nonsense knot, sweat pouring from her brow, rushing between steaming pots of Bengali delicacies was, I must confess, more than a little disconcerting. The food—*macher jhol*, *aloo poshto* and *kosha mangsho*—was fit for a Durga Puja banquet. When we left that evening, she made a Trinamool leader (who was also mayor of Kolkata!), carry large packets of ice cream into the